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The Dark Mysteries of the Castle of Good Hope

The Ghosts of Table Bay: Three Centuries of Haunting at South Africa's Oldest Fort

Aiden Nightfall

Free sample: Introduction & Chapter 1

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Introduction

At the foot of Table Mountain in Cape Town, South Africa, stands a star-shaped stone fortress that has been continuously occupied since 1679. The Castle of Good Hope is the oldest surviving colonial building in South Africa and one of the oldest European structures in sub-Saharan Africa. It is also, by the testimony of military personnel, museum staff, and visitors, one of the most haunted buildings on the continent.

The castle's ghost stories are unusual not because they are dramatic -- though some are -- but because they are documented. The "Lady in Grey," a female apparition seen walking through the castle, was first reported in the 1800s and described in official military correspondence. In 1947, a human face appeared on a wall in the castle's guard room -- not painted, not drawn, but apparently formed by damp staining the plaster. It was photographed by a castle official before the wall was cleaned. The face subsequently reappeared. This is one of the few documented cases of a supposedly paranormal visual phenomenon being photographed by an official at a government building.

The Castle of Good Hope has been a military fort, a government seat, a prison, a plague hospital, and now a museum. Over 350 years, thousands of people have lived, worked, and died within its walls. Soldiers were executed in its courtyard. Prisoners were held in its dungeons. Plague victims were buried nearby. The castle's history is a condensed record of colonial South Africa -- Dutch, then British, then South African -- and the ghosts said to inhabit it span that entire history.

This book investigates what has actually been reported at the Castle of Good Hope, what the historical records document, and what science can explain. It examines the 1947 face incident, the Lady in Grey, the ghost of Governor Pieter van Noodt, and the Black Dog, and it asks the question that defines this series: what is genuine, what is explained, and what remains unknown?

Chapter 1: What Happened Here?

The Castle of Good Hope stands in the center of Cape Town, near the harbor of Table Bay. It is a five-pointed star fort -- a design chosen to maximize defensive firepower along each wall -- built from local stone and imported brick. The original construction (1666-1679) was ordered by the Dutch East India Company (VOC) to replace an earlier clay-and-timber fort that had been built by Jan van Riebeeck when he established the VOC's refreshment station at the Cape in 1652.

The castle was originally built on the shoreline -- the sea lapped against its outer walls at high tide. Over three centuries of land reclamation, the shoreline has moved approximately 800 meters seaward, and the castle now sits inland, surrounded by the modern city. But its original position -- directly on the water, exposed to sea winds and damp -- has shaped both its physical condition and the character of the phenomena reported within it.

The castle complex includes five bastions (named after the main titles of the Prince of Orange), a moat (now dry), a main gateway, the Dolphin Pool, military barracks, the Governor's residence (the Kat), a chapel, and the infamous dungeon -- a windowless underground chamber used for holding prisoners. The castle served as the seat of government for the Dutch and later British colonial administration, as a military garrison, and as a prison. It has been in continuous use for over 340 years.

The earliest ghost stories associated with the Castle of Good Hope date to the late 18th century, though the castle was already a century old by then. The most significant early report involves Governor Pieter van Noodt, who governed the Cape Colony from 1727 to 1729. Van Noodt was reputed to be a cruel administrator who imposed harsh discipline on soldiers and servants. According to the legend, he sentenced seven soldiers to death for desertion, and on the day of their execution, one of the condemned men reportedly cursed van Noodt from the scaffold, calling down divine judgment. Van Noodt died suddenly the same day -- April 23, 1729 -- reportedly while sitting at his desk. His ghost is said to haunt the castle, particularly the area near the Dolphin Pool, where executions are believed to have taken place.

The "Lady in Grey" was first reported in the early 1800s, during the British occupation of the Cape. She is described as a tall woman in a long grey dress, seen walking through the castle -- sometimes through walls -- before vanishing. She was observed by multiple soldiers over a period of decades, and her appearances were noted in garrison records. The Lady in Grey is one of the few ghost apparitions at any location that was documented in official military correspondence, which gives her a level of institutional documentation that most

ghost stories lack.

The castle's haunted reputation was initially a military tradition -- known to soldiers stationed there but not widely publicized. This changed in the mid-20th century. In 1947, the most significant event in the castle's paranormal history occurred: a face appeared on a wall in the guard room. The face was not painted or drawn -- it appeared to have formed in the plaster itself, as if the wall had stained itself into the shape of a human face. The castle's commanding officer at the time, Colonel J.G. van Breda, had the face photographed before ordering the wall cleaned. The face reappeared after cleaning. It was photographed again and then plastered over. It reappeared a third time.

The 1947 incident was reported in the Cape Times and drew public attention to the castle's paranormal dimension. When the castle transitioned from a military installation to a museum in the late 20th century (the military formally withdrew in 2004, though the castle had been open to limited public access earlier), the ghost stories became a central part of the visitor experience. Today, the castle offers guided historical tours that include the haunted locations, and paranormal investigation teams regularly visit the site.

Witness Account
A South African National Defence Force soldier, stationed at the castle in the 1990s before the military's withdrawal, described his experience to a Cape Town newspaper: "I was on night guard duty, walking the perimeter. About 2am, near the Dolphin Pool, I heard footsteps behind me. I turned around -- nothing. I kept walking. The footsteps kept walking. I stopped. They stopped. I called out, identified myself. Nothing. I radioed the guardhouse. They said no one else was outside. I walked back to the guardhouse. The footsteps followed me all the way to the door. When I opened the door and turned around, there was nothing. I refused to walk that section alone after that."

Key Takeaways
- The Castle of Good Hope is South Africa's oldest colonial building (1666-1679) and has been continuously occupied for over 340 years.
- Early ghost reports include Governor Pieter van Noodt (died 1729, cursed by a condemned soldier) and the Lady in Grey, documented in official military correspondence from the 1800s.
- The 1947 "face on the wall" incident -- a face that appeared in plaster, was photographed, reappeared after cleaning, and was documented by the commanding officer -- brought the castle's haunting to public attention.